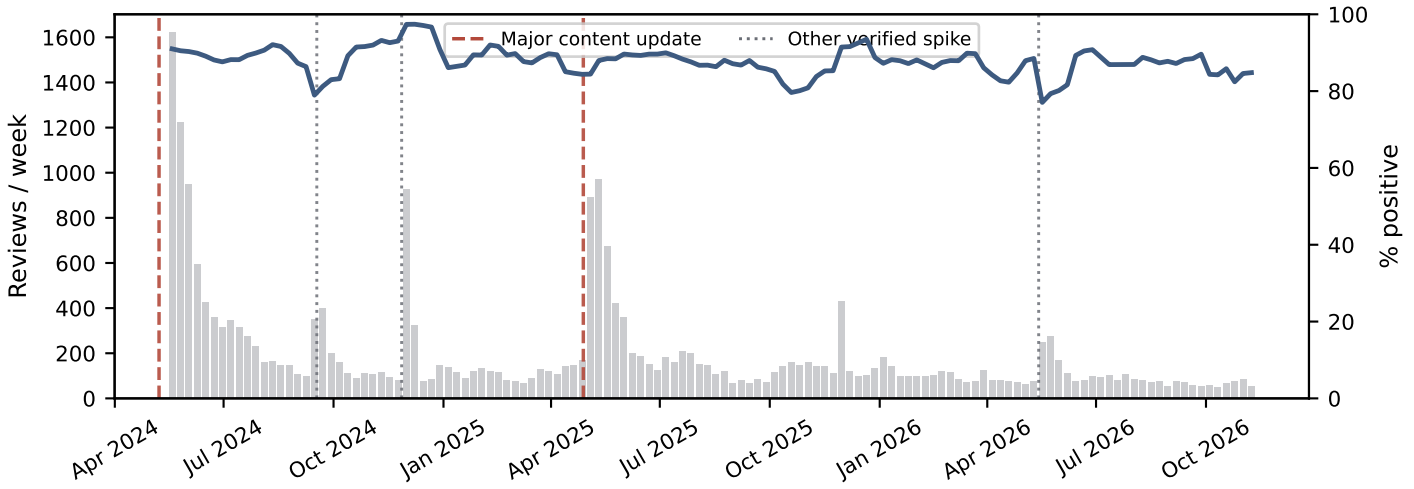
V Rising: Public Steam Review Analysis

English-language Steam reviews, 2024-05-14 to 2026-11-10 • n = 24,835 • 88% positive overall

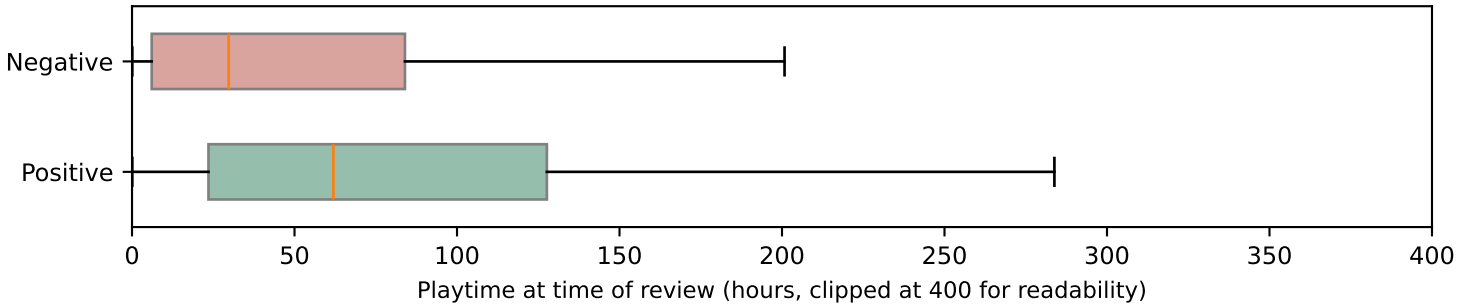
Independent fan analysis using Steam's public review data. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Stunlock Studios.

Review volume and % positive over time



Major updates (red dashed, left to right): 1.0 Launch (8 May 2024), Invaders of Oakveil (28 Apr 2025). Other verified spikes (gray dotted, left to right): 1.0.9.0 patch (17 Sep 2024), Steam Autumn Sale (27 Nov-4 Dec 2024), Free Weekend + 1.1.1 patch (14-18 May 2026). Unlabeled fluctuations elsewhere are not individually explained. Line is a 4-week rolling % positive; weeks below 20 reviews are masked, and the final partial week is excluded.

Playtime at review: positive vs. negative



Findings

1. Positive reviews have a higher median playtime at review (62h) than negative ones (30h): people who bounce off the game tend to say so earlier, not after a long investment.

2. Review volume spikes with each major update and decays back to baseline within roughly 6-8 weeks; % positive (4-week rolling) stays fairly stable through the same window, so volume, not sentiment, is the clearer signal of an update's reach.

3. Negative reviews cluster around six recurring, nameable themes rather than being diffuse (below), not a diagnosis of why but a map of where to look.

Recurring themes in negative reviews

TF-IDF + NMF topic model over negative reviews only. Each line is the model's theme plus one short, clean representative phrase (not a full quote).

1. Boss fights and gear progression feel unbalanced
"For context: I played solo only and defeated all the bosses in normal difficulty."

2. Updates sometimes force a new save to access new content
"Every update, they make it so you cant have your old save get the new content."

3. PvP/PvE server balance and solo-play friction
"This game is just not fun as a PvE player anymore."

4. Combat and the core loop feel slow, repetitive, or grindy
"Boring. Not playing again."

5. Camera and controller control issues
"Horrible camera controls on controller."

6. Solo play feels like more of a grind than with friends
"Not as much fun as it seems."

Limitations

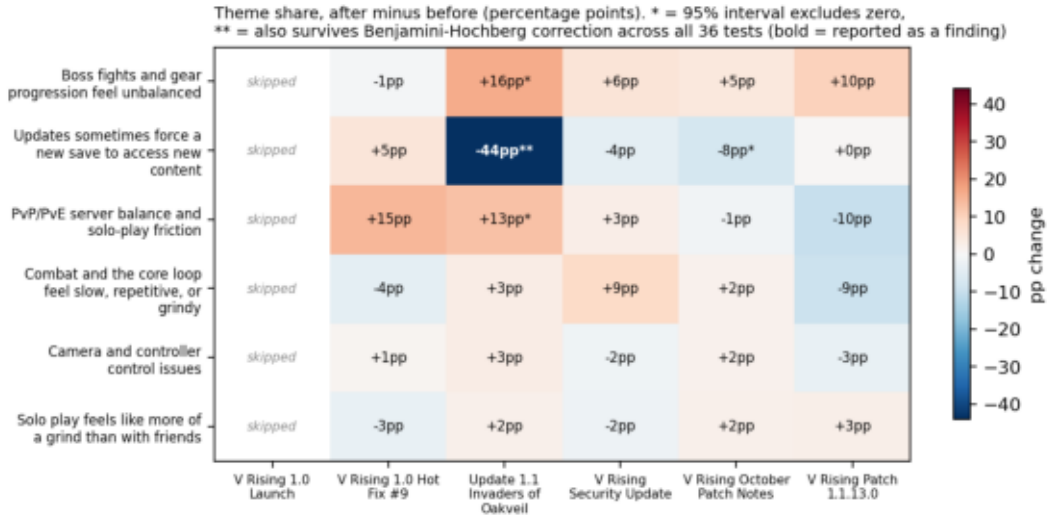
Steam reviewers are a self-selected, vocal subset of players, not a representative sample; this dataset is English-language reviews only; review text reflects stated opinion, not behavioral telemetry (e.g. actual churn points, session structure).

What internal telemetry could add: exact drop-off points, session length and return cadence by patch, and silent churn from players who never write a review at all.

Theme trends by patch

Each negative review is assigned 0+ of the six themes from page 1 (same TF-IDF + NMF model, not refit); a theme is assigned when its row-normalized NMF weight is >= 0.3. 271 of 2,860 negative reviews (9%) get no theme at all (mostly reviews too short to model). For each verified patch event (table below), a 4-week window before is compared to a 4-week window after, skipping the release week itself; windows under 30 negative reviews are skipped and marked so. Intervals are 95% (Wilson for each share, normal-approximation for the difference). A shift is reported as a finding below only if it survives all of: the 95% interval excluding zero, Benjamini-Hochberg correction across all tests, and two robustness checks (raw unnormalized NMF weights, and the same comparison as a share of all reviews rather than negative reviews only) that guard against a row-normalization side effect: when one theme's weight collapses, the other five can mechanically look larger in share terms with no real independent change.





Findings

1. The one shift that survives every check here (95% interval, raw-weight robustness check, all-reviews robustness check, and Benjamini-Hochberg correction across all 30 tests): around "Update 1.1 Invaders of Oakveil", "Updates sometimes force a new save to access new content" moved -44pp (95% CI -55 to -33pp) (n=88 before, 251 after).

2. 3 other shift(s) looked significant on the original 95% interval alone but did not survive the full check: "Update 1.1 Invaders of Oakveil" / "Boss fights and gear progression feel unbalanced" (+16pp originally); "Update 1.1 Invaders of Oakveil" / "PvP/PvE server balance and solo-play friction" (+13pp originally); "V Rising October Patch Notes" / "Updates sometimes force a new save to access new content" (-8pp originally). These are consistent with a row-normalization side effect (six per-review weights sum to 1, so a collapse in one theme mechanically inflates the others' share) rather than an independent signal, and are not reported as findings.

3. Out of 30 event-theme pairs with enough data to test, only the one finding above holds up end to end. Everything else, including every theme around both hotfix-type events, the October 2025 patch, and Patch 1.1.13.0, does not move in a way this method can distinguish from noise once corrected for multiple testing. If a theme doesn't move, that's the honest result, not a gap in the analysis.

4. "Camera and controller control issues" and "Solo play feels like more of a grind than with friends" show no significant shift around any verified event tested here: a stable background complaint, not something that visibly responds to a specific patch.

5. This is correlation keyed to release dates, not a causal test: free weekends, platform-wide sales, and influencer waves can land in the same windows (see page 1) and are not separated out here, so even the one confirmed shift may partly reflect something other than the patch itself.